and then the Mughals:

> By the time the Mughals unified the land the Indian people had already pledged their allegiance to a different people. To be owned by the Mughals and then to be owned by the British what difference did it make to them.

The weather in India was also cited as a reason for Indian laziness and lack of vigour. Zhang Taiyan observed:

> Don't you know in the tropics people do not go cold and hungry therefore people become lazy and things go easily rotten. They are weaker than you [Kang] saw. [3]

These scholars did not see the irony of their blaming the Indians' supposedly deficient character for their falling prey to foreign rule and ignoring their own country's history of having been conquered and ruled by the alien Mongols in the twelfth and thirteenth centuries as the Yuan dynasty, and later by the Manchus from the seventeenth to the twentieth centuries as the Qing dynasty.

If the Indians were themselves responsible for falling prey to alien rule, then were the Hans during the Ming dynasty also responsible for falling prey to the Manchus? Were there similar character faults at play? These questions never surfaced in the Chinese discourse.

During this phase, even the positive history of Buddhism as a factor of affinity between the two countries was reinterpreted negatively. Liang Shuming, for example, said that for the reinvigoration of China, Indian influence must be eliminated and not a trace of it be allowed to survive in China. Some years later, Hu Shih took up this theme and argued in an address at Harvard University in 1937 that the Chinese weakness in confronting Japanese aggression was due to the 'Indianization of China'. According to Hu Shih:

> India conquered and dominated China culturally for 20 centuries without ever having to send a single soldier across her border. [4]

But he meant this to convey that India's baneful influence on China be exorcised rather than celebrated. His statement is often misinterpreted in India as a grateful Chinese acknowledgement of its cultural debt to India, when its intent is quite the opposite. In October 2017, Rajnath Singh, the Indian Defence Minister, approvingly quoted Hu Shih's remarks as evidence of China's cultural debt to India, only to invite a prompt and angry